Today the steel of the MVA is necessary to protect Maharashtra dharma from the clutches of gaddars (traitors), who are solely motivated by a lust for power. These forces have colluded with the new Shahs of New India to mortgage our sanskriti (culture), swarajya (self-rule) and swabhimaan (dignity). Consequently, Maharashtra is facing a mass exodus of industrial investments. Our youth are facing historic unemployment. Our agricultural sector, once the pride of India, is in a shambles, with more than 1,023 farmers dying by suicide in just the past six months. Rising prices of food items are adversely impacting every household in Maharashtra.

Some of these grave concerns could have been redressed by local bodies. However, the Shinde–Fadnavis government has refused to conduct local body elections and illegally appropriated the financial and functional powers of twenty-seven municipal corporations in Maharashtra. In one stroke, they have robbed the Maharashtrian public of its agency and voice. Displaying a streak of authoritarianism, they have also taken control of over Rs 1.10 lakh crores of funds that these municipal corporations could have used for people's welfare.[1]

When Shiv Sena was raising these legitimate concerns, the new Shahs of New India dastardly tried to break our spirit and voice. This is symptomatic of a perverted belief that India should be run by a single party, which is why the Bharatiya Janata Party has tried to cannibalize every coalition party it has allied with. This is deeply anti-federal and antinational. But the BJP has failed to understand that our core strength comes from the Marathi people and the Shivsainiks, who are united in their desire to further Maharashtra's asmita (pride) and aakansha (aspiration). They have failed to understand that every partner in the MVA is united in ensuring Maharashtra's development, prosperity and progress.

In the continued pursuit of this vision and to fight for the legitimate concerns of our people, I decided to join the Bharat Jodo Yatra along with my colleagues. I discussed many of these issues with Rahul Gandhi, who was extremely empathetic to each of these concerns. He was deeply interested in learning about minute issues that our state faces. Beyond these concerns, our discussions touched upon the stifling of dissenting voices by